

1, Why Write This Massive Chapter

If potential readers have read from the beginning to this point, they should already be highly familiar with my historical perspectives. Even if I were to omit this section, they could likely deduce my general views on historical periodization.

People might accuse me of being excessively radical: *I originally set out merely to comprehend the historical processes that transpired in China, yet now I have entangled myself in the macro-development of the entire human civilization. This hardly seems like something an ordinary Chinese university student should be undertaking.*

I do not deny this in the slightest. Nor is it possible that I have never doubted myself. I am an ordinary person—as ordinary as one can possibly be. How dare I covet the monumental feats that only heroes like Sir Isaac Newton could achieve? Even so, I have decided to write down these words, and I wish to first explain my reasons here.

First, my reflections on the practical issues of China have ultimately and profoundly altered my worldview, and especially my historical perspective. How to periodize history is fundamentally an essential issue within one's historical perspective. Therefore, if I do not document the conclusions I have reached after critically subsuming (扬弃) the various historical periodization theories proposed by predecessors dating back to the dawn of religion, I would essentially be omitting the absolute core of my thinking.

Second, after obtaining preliminary conclusions based on the histories of China, Japan, and Europe, I tested these conclusions utilizing the various historical stages of other regions across the globe. In my view, the results of this testing are exceptionally gratifying! This theory, derived from contemplating Chinese history, obviously does not apply exclusively to a single nation like China. This theory can holistically explain the significance and status of each stage in the developmental trajectory of human civilization to date.

Furthermore, it substantially eliminates the interference of **social concepts** (社会观念) like culture and religion, demonstrating that these **social concepts** themselves are inherently not **independent variables** (自变量) dictating social development. Rather, they exert their impact on social development as intervening variables (中间变量), shaped by the fundamental structure constituted by the social **productive forces** (生产力) and the relations among various social strata. Moreover, the practice of excessively appealing to the personal virtues of historical figures when seeking historical explanations—a practice that wise individuals find utterly repugnant—has now been entirely swept away.

Truthfully, what I desperately want to say is this: almost everything I have observed had already been noticed by pioneers much earlier. If the theoretical system I am about to articulate is viewed as a whole elephant, the various parts of this elephant have long been thoroughly palpated by others; however, for various reasons, no one ever explicitly pointed out that these are indeed parts of the same elephant.

Third, some might question whether subsuming the entire developmental process of humanity into a single framework is unnecessary, or even potentially dangerous. I still do not deny this.

When I was young, I read many science fiction novels imbued with an apocalyptic (启示录意味) tone, written by both Chinese and foreign authors. These novels told stories where, in the future,

humanity abused genetic engineering to uniformly modify the human race in pursuit of smarter and stronger offspring. Although this project initially achieved success, the excessively homogenized human genome proved utterly defenseless against unforeseeable microbial mutations.

Although biological genetics and the human societal level are oceans apart, sociology is precisely such a discipline where no one can provide an exact proof for *any* theory, because you can fundamentally never conduct repeatable experiments! Thus, no one can definitively claim that a social system currently deemed backward or flawed won't exhibit obvious advantages under certain conditions, nor that such conditions will never arise.

But what I want to express is this: **You cannot possibly worry about the (purely potential) side effects of a prescription when administering medicine to a terminally ill patient.**

The reality facing the world we see today is that various nations' emphasis on their own "particularities" has reached a level of catastrophic destructiveness. How many regimes have existed in the past—and how many still exist today—that deceive their citizens by claiming: *"Our nation is uniquely exceptional, and we must absolutely not tread the same developmental path as those inferior nations or foreigners!"*? **They use this as a pretext either to launch massive wars of aggression, or to justify their own tyrannical and abusive rule at home.**

From the 1920s to the present day, such an array of atrocities has resulted in the unnatural deaths of tens of millions across the globe. This lesson is simply too profound and too agonizing.

Unlike the ordinary citizens of developed nations—for whom memories of the Nazis have largely faded by my generation, and where the elderly who remember fascist dictatorships and aggression are few and far between—I personally currently live in exactly such an environment that relentlessly propagandizes the "uniqueness" of its civilization. And I know full well that it is not just one country generating such political propaganda. In the Third World nations across Asia, Africa, and Latin America, **"a developmental path with our nation's own characteristics"** (本国特色的发展道路) is practically a trendy catchphrase.

Must we really tolerate these lies continuing to inflict horrific damage upon human civilization solely for the sake of an illusory, or even blatantly erroneous, "fantasy of diversity" (多元化的幻想) that posits "there are millions of distinct paths to modernization for different nations"?

As I have read more and more books over the past two years, I have become increasingly convinced that the commonalities among all nations and ethnicities vastly outweigh their differences. The "differences" people perceive are fundamentally not intrinsic, biological disparities between two ethnic groups, but rather the resultant products of the distinct societies in which they live. Ambitious politicians constantly exploit this fact for propaganda, intentionally confusing ordinary citizens.

What I aim to accomplish is to fundamentally negate this exaggerated concept of distinctiveness! **No matter how brilliant or intelligent a nation is perceived to be in the public imagination, it absolutely cannot escape the fundamental theories delineated by the social sciences. Conversely, no matter how inferior or foolish a nation is perceived to be, when all social conditions are appropriate, it is entirely capable of accomplishing the monumental feats achieved by any other nation.**

By doing so, the very bedrock underlying any racist viewpoints, and any atrocities committed under the shield of "national exceptionalism" (本民族特殊论) to enact reactionary rule, will be completely pulverized.

Rational people will understand that positing universal laws for the development of human society absolutely does not equate to denying diversity or its significance. Nations like Western Europe and Japan, which successfully traversed the various historical processes to eventually achieve modernization and become developed regions, exhibit massive cultural differences among themselves, each possessing its own unique charm.

In the previous chapter, I also explicitly and frankly acknowledged that the "temporal lag" (时差) generated by the social stages of different regions can indeed possess positive significance. For example, the continuation of classical systems by the Arab and Byzantine Empires contributed monumentally to preserving the classical civilization achievements of Greece and Rome, ultimately facilitating the modernization of Europe.

At the dawn of the 20th century, humanity first left the earth and soared into the sky; barely more than half a century later, human footprints were already imprinted on the moon. I do not harbor the slightest doubt that allowing various "**nationalized social sciences**" (民族的社会科学) to run rampant, as they do today, will be a catastrophic loss for the entirety of human civilization. If extraterrestrials are currently observing Earth, they would likely laugh at us.

Just as Sir Isaac Newton revealed the fundamental architecture of the world system, thereby terminating the era of "nationalized (natural) sciences," people today should similarly strive to seek universal truths within the social sciences! What humanity should do is maintain a constant sense of reverence and caution—ensuring we do not repeat the catastrophic errors of Marx and Engels that left a legacy of disaster lasting a century—rather than abandoning the pursuit of universal truth altogether.

Ultimately, I embarked on this incredibly long journey driven by contemplation regarding the destiny of my own nation and my compatriots. Along the way, I have witnessed countless magnificent vistas. As this journey reaches a natural hiatus, I wish to refocus the lens back onto "**humanity**" (人)—even though, when studying history, people spend the vast majority of their time looking at macro-narratives of the rise and fall of empires.

I believe that if we can provide a unified narrative for the historical processes of all nations under heaven, it will, at least in the present, hold immensely positive significance for enhancing mutual understanding among the peoples of all nations, and for halting the suffering currently endured by the overwhelming majority of humanity! (*Do not forget that out of the current global population of over 8 billion, fewer than 1.5 billion live in developed nations*).

I believe there is absolutely no necessity to abandon immediate, completely visible welfare merely due to potential "side effects." Therefore, I audaciously toss out this humble brick here, in the hope of attracting jade (抛砖引玉 / *to offer a humble idea to elicit profound insights*).

Because this section is exceedingly vast and complex, readers may first consult Section 30 of this chapter, where I have provided the definitions for the concepts I will be employing.

1, 为什么要写这一大章

如果潜在的读者能从头读到这里, 那么对于我的历史观点应该已经十分熟悉了, 即使我不写这一段恐怕也能够猜出我对历史分期的大致看法。人们或许会指责我太激进, 原本只是想了解中国所发生的历史进程, 现在却牵扯到了整个人类文明的发展, 实在不像一个普普通通的中国大学生该做的事。我一点也不否认这一点, 更不可能从来没有自我怀疑过, 我是一个平凡的再也不能平凡的人, 怎么敢觊觎牛顿爵士那样的英雄才能实现的伟业呢? 即使如此, 我还是决定写下这些文字, 我想在这里先解释一下原因。

第一, 对中国现实问题的思考最终深刻改变了我的世界观特别是历史观, 而如何对历史进行分期则是历史观中的一个本质问题, 因此如果我不写下我对上溯到宗教初兴的年代前人所提出的各种历史分期理论进行扬弃后得到的结果, 那么我将实际上漏掉我思考的核心部分。

第二, 在根据中国、日本和欧洲的历史初步得到结论之后, 利用全世界其他地区的各个历史阶段对结论进行了检验。在我看来, 检验的效果是非常喜人的, 这个从对中国历史的思考中所得到的理论显然不只适用于中国一个国家。这个理论可以在整体上解释人类文明迄今为止的发展历程中各个阶段的重要地位和, 并相当程度地排除了文化、宗教这些社会观念的影响, 说明这些社会观念本身不是决定社会发展的自变量, 而是作为一个受社会生产力以及社会各阶层之关系所构成的基本结构所影响的中间变量对社会发展产生影响。而那些在明智的人们看来令人厌恶的, 在寻求历史解释时过度诉诸历史人物个人德行的行为, 如今也被一扫而空。其实我非常想说的是, 我所看到的每一件事, 几乎总是先行者在更早的时候就已经注意到了。如果把我接下来要叙述的理论体系视为一整个大象, 那么这个大象的各个部分早就已经被人摸透了, 但是因为种种原因并没有人明确指出这就是大象的某个部分。

第三, 或许会有人质疑, 把整个人类的发展历程纳入一个框架下是无必要的, 甚至有潜在的危险。我依然不否认这一点, 在我小的时候就曾经读到过许多具有启示录意味的科幻小说, 无论是中国作者还是外国作者写的都有。这些小说讲述这样的故事, 未来人类为了获得更聪明强壮的后代, 滥用基因技术对人类进行了整齐划一的改造, 虽然这个工程在一开始取得了成功, 但是过于同质化的人类基因却难以抵御一些无法预料的微生物突变。虽然生物基因层面跟人类社会层面相隔甚远, 然而社会学就是这样一个学科, 任何人都没办法对任何理论给出精确的证明, 因为你永远无法进行重复实验。于是没有人能说, 现在被视为落后的、错误的社会体制, 在一定的条件下不会具有明显的优势, 并且这种条件永远不会出现。但是我想表达的是, 你不能再给一个病重垂危的人开药方的时候还考虑药的(压根就是潜在的)副作用, 我们今天所见到的世界面临的现实情况是, 各个国家强调本国的特殊性已经到了一种造成极大破坏的程度。曾经有过, 现在还有多少政权, 欺骗他们的老百姓说我们民族是独特的, 我们必然不跟那些劣等民族或者外国人走一样的发展道路, 它们或者以此为借口发动大规模的侵略战争, 或者以此为本国的暴虐统治辩护。

自 20 世纪 20 年代至今, 这样林林总总的恶行, 在整个地球上所造成的人口非正常死亡以千万计, 这个教训实在是太过深刻了。与发达国家的老百姓不同, 他们对于纳粹的记忆到我这个年代已然很淡了, 对于法西斯专政和侵略有记忆的老人已经所剩无几。可是我本人现在就生活在这样一个宣扬本文明独特的环境下, 而且我也知道做出这样的政治宣传的不只是一个国家, 在亚非拉的第三世界国家, “本国特色的发展道路”简直是时髦话。难道仅仅是为了虚无缥缈的, 甚至干脆错误的“各民族现代化的道路千千万万”这么一个“多元化的幻想”, 我们就应该容忍这些谎言继续对整个人类文明造成伤害吗? 在过去两年里随着我看的书越来越多, 我越来越确信各个国家, 各个民族之间的共性要大于差异, 人们观念中的“差异”并非两个族群之间真的有生理上的本质不同, 而是他们所生活的社会不同导致的。野心勃勃的政治家常常利用这一点进行宣传, 使普通百姓变得更为疑惑。我想做的事情就是, 从根本上否定这种被夸大的差异性, 一个民族哪怕在人们的印象中再优秀, 再聪明, 它也没办法逃脱出社会科学所指出的基

本理论，一个民族，哪怕在人们的印象里再低劣，再愚蠢，当一切社会条件都合适的时候，它也足以完成其他任何民族可以实现的事业。这样一来，任何种族主义的观点，任何以本民族特殊论为盾牌行反动统治之实的恶行都将完全失去基石。

理智的人们会明白，认为人类社会发展具有一般规律当然不是在否认多元性及其意义，像西欧和日本这样顺利经历了各个历史进程最终实现现代化成为发达地区的国家，它们的文化之间也有很大的差异，各有各的魅力。在上一个章节我也直言不讳地承认，各个地区社会阶段产生的时差确实可以存在积极意义，例如阿拉伯帝国和拜占庭帝国对于古典体制的延续就对保护希腊和罗马的古典文明成果贡献很大，最终有利于欧洲的近代化。在 20 世纪的开始，人类第一次离开大地飞向天空，又过了仅仅半个世纪多，人类的足迹就已经踏上了月球。我绝不怀疑像今天这样任由各种“民族的社会科学”泛滥成灾将是整个人类文明的损失，如果有外星人正在观察地球的话，它们大概也会笑话吧！就像牛顿当年揭示了世界体系的基本面貌，从而终结了“各民族的（自然）科学”一样，现在的人们也应该努力在社会科学中寻找普遍真理。人们所做的应该是常怀敬畏和谨慎之心，不要再犯马克思、恩格斯那样遗祸百年的错误，而不是放弃这样的追求。

最后，我是怀着对自己国家和同胞命运的思考踏上这段漫长的旅途，一路走来看到了无数壮丽的景色。在旅途告一段落的时候，我想把视角重新聚焦在“人”身上，尽管人们在了解历史的时候大部分时间都是在看宏观的兴亡故事。我认为如果能够对各国历史进程给出一个统一的叙事，至少在当下来看，对于增进各国人民对彼此之间的了解，制止全世界绝大多数人民所忍受的苦难（不要忘了现在全球 80 多亿人口中，生活在发达国家的还不足 15 亿）具有积极意义。我认为实在没有必要为可能的“副作用”，就放弃眼下的完全可见的福祉，因此斗胆在这抛下引玉之砖。因为这一部分太过庞杂，因此读者可以先看本章的第三十节，我在那里给出了将要使用概念的定义。